

The events of August 21 were the last straw. Henry Cabot Lodge, who arrived in Saigon to take over from Nolting, was convinced that Diem had to go. The Buddhists were more than prepared for that eventuality. Tri Quang had already secretly met with US Embassy officials and encouraged the US to take action, noting that they were partly responsible for the situation in South Vietnam. US leaders, however, blamed Diem and Nhu.

» AFTER

The Buddhist crisis—and Nhu's violent response to it—erased the last shred of confidence that US leaders had in Diem's regime in South Vietnam.

SANCTIONED REMOVAL

South Vietnamese generals began plotting the **overthrow of Diem** and his brother. President Kennedy and US Ambassador Lodge concurred. Kennedy authorized Lodge to let the generals know that, while the US would not assist them in mounting a coup, it would support them afterward.

Despite the generals' hopes, Diem's removal **did not bring order** to South Vietnam. The generals' military junta was weak, and more **coups would follow**. The Viet Cong continued to make inroads in South Vietnam, eager to take advantage of this political instability.